

Chamber music

As its name suggests, chamber music was played for enjoyment in private homes. Before public concerts were established in the 19th century, evenings of playing and listening to music were a popular form of entertainment for the wealthy.

▷ Chamber music combinations

In addition to the solo or duo sonata (keyboard alone or with another instrument), the string quartet was a favorite kind of chamber music.

Players	Instruments
3	Piano trios—1 violin, 1 cello, 1 piano—eg Schubert
4	String quartet—2 violins, 1 viola, 1 cello—eg Haydn
5	String quintet—2 violins, 2 violas, 1 cello—eg Mozart
6	String sextet—2 violins, violas, cellos—eg Boccherini
7	Septet—1 each violin, viola, cello, double bass, clarinet, bassoon, French horn—eg Beethoven
8	Octet—2 each oboes, clarinets, bassoons, French horns—eg Mozart
9	Nonet—1 each of violin, viola, cello, double bass, flute, oboe, clarinet, bassoon, French horn—eg Louis Spohr

Orchestral music

Four-movement symphonies and three-movement concertos for piano and violin were the most popular orchestral pieces. Balance and order were important, so that a coherent, pleasing musical whole could be created for the listener to enjoy.

Composer	Symphonies composed
Ludwig van Beethoven (1770–1827)	9
Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart (1756–91)	41
Johann Stamitz (1717–57)	58
Joseph Haydn (1732–1809)	106
Franz Xaver Pokorny (1729–94)	More than 140

△ Symphonies

In the late 1700s, the German Court of Mannheim valued music highly—employing renowned players and composers. It became regarded as the “home” of the symphony and the center of excellent orchestral playing.

REAL WORLD

Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart (1756–91)

Often regarded as the supreme composer of the Classical period, Mozart was one of the first “freelance” composers. For most of his working life, he did not hold a court or church position, relying for income on public concerts and commissions—requests for new compositions—from individual patrons.



Opera and oratorio

During the Classical period, opera flourished across Europe. Opera houses opened, offering a favorite social pastime for the wealthy. With arias, choruses, and instrumental items, oratorio was musically similar to opera, but was based on religious themes and was performed without action, sets, or costumes.



△ Haydn's *The Creation*

Haydn's oratorio *The Creation* depicts the creation of the world. The lilting aria “With verdure clad” describes the serene countryside.